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Tony Strickland: Legislative Democrats' Bizarro World

August 7, 2026 | Orange County Register, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)
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OpenURL Link

"Bizarro World" is a place where everything is backwards, where words mean the opposite of actions, and where common sense is turned upside down. That is how I describe Sacramento and legislative Democrats, who talk about fighting for affordability but do the opposite.

In 2026, Sacramento Democrats and the governor promised that affordability would be a guiding priority. In January, Governor Gavin Newsom presented his state budget as a plan that would supposedly address affordability and support Californians. In March, Assembly Democrats announced their legislative priorities, saying they were "fighting for affordability" while highlighting housing, health care, and responsible government. Senate Democrats also claimed to emphasize affordability in their budget framework, saying they were focused on "the people feeling the greatest financial strain: working families and the middle class." But words alone do not lower the cost of living. Don't listen to the rhetoric. Look at the record.

I hear from constituents who are doing everything right, working hard, paying their bills, and trying to provide for their families. Yet they feel that living in California is becoming harder for them. They pay more for groceries, rent, gas, electricity, insurance, and everyday necessities. Small business owners face rising costs that make it harder to keep their doors open and create jobs. Young Californians wonder whether they will ever be able to afford a home in the communities where they grew up.

Despite repeated promises about addressing affordability, Sacramento Democrats push policies that will make California more expensive for families, students, and small businesses.

This year, they approved $14 billion in massive new taxes that will increase costs for all Californians, including a new software tax that will impact businesses that rely on digital services to operate. If you are a small business owner who depends on software for accounting, payroll, or point-of-sale systems, you can expect higher costs. And a new private healthcare tax means families of four can expect to pay an estimated $425 more per year.

This year's budget is a whopping $352 billion, $5 billion more than what was proposed in the May Revision. The AI boom has brought in record-breaking revenues, which means there is no excuse for raising taxes.

A simple first step to address California's affordability crisis would be to pause the state gas tax, which is why I introduced legislation this year to provide relief to drivers. However, Sacramento Democrats and the governor declined to support a one-year suspension of the state gas tax. California drivers pay the highest gas prices in the nation, more than $1.50 per gallon above the national average, costing families hundreds of dollars more each year just to fill up their cars.

Californians are now paying 63.4 cents per gallon in state gas taxes. When Senate Bill 1 was enacted in 2017, the gas tax was 29.7 cents per gallon. In less than a decade, it has more than doubled. This increase is automatic and takes effect every year on July 1.

What is especially frustrating is that I have given my Democratic colleagues multiple opportunities to join me in suspending the gas tax, yet they have repeatedly failed to take meaningful action to provide relief for California drivers.

This proposal was a practical one. Nationally, the governors of Georgia, Indiana, and Utah have temporarily suspended their states' gas taxes to help residents manage rising fuel costs. In Congress, U.S. Senators Mark Kelly and Richard Blumenthal, both Democrats, introduced the Gas Prices Relief Act, which would temporarily suspend

the federal 18.4-cent-per-gallon gas tax through October 1, 2026, to help lower gas prices for drivers.

If affordability is truly the priority, this year's budget does not reflect it. Californians want leaders who understand the challenges they face and make decisions that help them get ahead. Affordability should not be a slogan used during budget season or election year and should be the standard by which every policy decision is judged.

Instead, Sacramento has become Bizarro World, a place where the party in charge promises affordability while making Californians pay more.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Strickland, T. (2026, August 7). Tony Strickland: Legislative Democrats' Bizarro World.*Orange County Register, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A9E2334589E4AB8.